

Case Studies and Stories - Sources and Verification Notes

This document explains the public data sources, federal reports, and official statistics that support the themes illustrated in the case studies. Each case study is a fictionalized composite based on patterns that appear in verified national datasets.

1. Housing Instability Sources

Housing-related case studies reflect public data from the Census Bureau American Community Survey (ACS), the Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD) Fair Market Rent datasets, and the Federal Housing Finance Agency (FHFA) House Price Index. These sources show consistent increases in rent burden, rising home values, and displacement linked to investor-owned properties.

2. Childcare Cost Sources

Childcare case studies are anchored in Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) reports, Department of Labor childcare cost indexes, and Census data on parental labor-force participation. These datasets consistently show that childcare often exceeds housing costs in many states, causing parents to leave the workforce.

3. Medical Debt and Healthcare Sources

Healthcare stories reflect national findings from the Census Household Economic Well-Being report, BLS medical inflation data, and Federal Reserve surveys showing that unexpected medical bills are a major contributor to household debt. High-deductible plans and surprise billing trends are well documented across these sources.

4. Wages vs. Cost of Living Sources

Work and income case studies are based on BLS wage growth data, Real Earnings reports, CPI inflation data, and FRED series that show the gap between wage increases and rising prices. The pattern of real wages failing to keep pace with inflation appears across multiple federal datasets.

5. Transportation Cost Sources

Transportation case studies are connected to BLS transportation inflation data, FRED gas-price indexes, insurance cost reports, and Department of Transportation data showing that commutes are getting longer and more expensive. These sources document the rising costs of owning and maintaining a vehicle.

6. Education Cost Sources

Education-related case studies draw from Census expenditure reports, National Center for Education Statistics (NCES) data on school fees, and inflation indexes for school supplies and electronics. These sources show rising costs that fall directly on families.

7. Cross-Cutting Economic Stress Indicators

General financial stress themes are supported by Federal Reserve surveys of household economic stability, Census Household Pulse Survey responses, and national statistics on emergency savings. These show that many households cannot cover unexpected expenses and live month-to-month.

8. Verification Note

All sources referenced here are publicly available federal datasets. No private or proprietary data was used. Case studies do not reflect any specific individual. They summarize common economic pressures documented across these official sources.